

## Skullcandy PLYR1

Skullcandy's new gaming headphones features a foldable boom mic, inline remote for controlling the volume, and selecting trio of EQ



## LG Optimus G

LG has officially launched its new flagship in Korea and is expected to release globally in November. Optimus G is estimated at ₹48,500

**HD Media Players**

## HOW WE TESTED

When comparing HD media players, we ensured that everything that would impact the performance was kept constant throughout.

### The updates

Before we started, we checked if there were any updates available for the software, and if there were, we downloaded and installed them as recommended.

### Videos and formats

We handpicked a bunch of 1080p, 720p and SD videos in various popular formats – MKV, MP4, AVI, m2ts, RMVB and MOV that we played back on all devices one by one. The performance of these videos was a huge chunk of

the performance testing, including quality and playback start times.

### The display

The media players were connected via a Panasonic HDMI cable to a Samsung Series 6 LED television, and always in the same input source, with the picture and audio settings constant throughout. Even the power source was kept exactly the same, to allow for a completely level playing field.

### The storage

We used the Seagate Backup Plus 1TB (USB 3.0) drive in NTFS format, and a Seagate Sandisk Cruzer Blade, 16GB USB drive in Fat32 format, running the files off a single-layer folder structure.

### The network

To test streaming services, we used a Cisco-Linksys X2000 Wireless N router (A/B/G/N), which was connected to a Windows 7 Ultimate PC running a PS3 media server. The distance between the router and the media players was also kept constant.

### The remote

In order to test the remotes, we measured performance from identically measured distances, and ensured that there was never any interference, physical or otherwise, between the remote and the players.

We also looked at the features provided, and marked everything down, as shown in the table on page 62.

and streaming capabilities, but only via Ethernet. Incidentally, there is no price limitation in the first and second category, since the devices are clustered based on hardware criteria. Yes, some manufacturers may offer the optional Wi-Fi dongle, but we consider that as a separate expense since it doesn't come out of the box with the device. The third category includes media players costing up to ₹8,000 and get inbuilt Wi-Fi capabilities. The final category is the ones which feature the high-end media players, costing above ₹8,000, and offer a wide gamut of features.

## PRETTY LASSES

### Design and ergonomics

Unlike Blu-ray and DVD players, HD media players don't have similar designs. You get to see a wide variety of form factors across the board.

The O!Play Mini is a basic media player offering from ASUS, and is the cheapest in this test. The desk area it takes up is pretty similar to a USB hard drive, which is small. It's not built to look like a budget

media player at all, and the shiny plastic used on the top of the device has a pretty decent imprint design.

All the connectors can be found at the back, and only the USB port and the memory card reader are in the front. Now this is handy, but with something this small, we think aesthetics should have won here, and these slots could have been at the back instead of spoiling the show. This is painfully obvious when you see the thing sitting there with a USB cable running out of it into an external drive.

Being devices that usually sit near your TV, which is also, usually a focus area of your living room, it's good to see that even budget or affordable media players take note of this. The Amkette Flash TV HD, for example, is reminiscent of a rounded coffee table coaster, and is not much thicker (base to top) than a Tata Sky HD remote. The device easily slides inbetween the base and screen of most HDTVs – good for those of you with space commanding a premium. It will just as easily sit on top of a set-top box or a Blu-ray

player as well. Despite the slim design, the connectivity options are all there – HDMI, component and composite out. Our only

complaint is the single USB port, and just one SD card slot.

The O!Play HDP R1/2A is significantly larger than the



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